India’s Modi to visit Brussels as trade deal signing beckons

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By Camille Gijs · Oct 14, 2026, 1:06 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Brussels on Dec. 16, a senior European Commission official confirmed Wednesday, raising expectations that the EU and India will formally sign their long-awaited trade agreement.

“We will have Prime Minister Modi in Brussels on Dec. 16,” Tomas Baert, trade adviser to Ursula von der Leyen, told the Commission’s Trade Policy Day in Brussels.

Baert didn’t elaborate on the purpose of the visit. But the Commission has been pushing to complete the formalities needed to sign the long-awaited trade agreement before the end of the year.

Modi’s visit is scheduled for the eve of the year’s final summit of EU leaders.

The agreement still requires approval from EU capitals before it can be signed. EU ambassadors are expected to vote on Dec. 9, followed by ministers on Dec. 11, an EU official said.

Negotiations concluded earlier this year on a deal to open markets spanning 2 billion people and accounting for more than a fifth of global GDP. European carmakers and drinks companies will gain greater access to the Indian market, while New Delhi won concessions on pharmaceuticals and services. Brussels wants the deal to enter into force before next summer.

Unlike the EU-Mercosur trade agreement, whose approval was postponed last December after supporters failed to muster the required majority, the India deal enjoys broad backing among EU governments — in part because it largely excludes sensitive agricultural products.

France has, however, resisted a Commission push to fast-track trade agreements, including the India deal, by approving English-language texts before they have been translated into the EU’s other 23 official languages, POLITICO reported last month .

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